RUB | SOMMERSEMESTER 2026

Grammar BM

Complete Exam Guide

Central exam
Friday, 24 July 2026 | 14:00-16:00 | 90 minutes | 100 points

Source priority
Official SoSe 2026 Theory Reader -> Moodle mock feedback -> new-format exercises -> old exams for extra practice.

Online trainer
https://sirmrba.github.io/grammar-sprint/

Prepared as a focused exam aid. The examples are original practice items derived from the official grammar rules.

ORIENTATION

1. Exam blueprint and study strategy

The official SoSe 2026 mock contains six sections and totals 100 points. The first four sections test form selection in context. Theory questions test rule recognition. Translation combines several targets in one sentence.

Section	Format	Points	What to do
Non-finites	15 gaps	15	identify the governor and intended meaning
Tense and aspect	20 gaps	20	establish time line, then aspect
Modal items	15 gaps	15	classify meaning before choosing form
Relative clauses	10 gaps	10	decide type, antecedent and case
Theory and analysis	15 MC	15	state the rule and reject near-misses
Translation	10 sentences	25	build grammar first, then polish wording

THREE-DAY ROUTE

Day	Main work	Finish with
Tue 21 Jul	diagnostic; non-finites; tense and aspect	10 translations
Wed 22 Jul	modals; relative clauses; weak cards	20-question mixed drill
Thu 23 Jul	word order; determiners; translation	full 90-minute mock
Fri 24 Jul	saved mistakes; last-minute guide	stop before overload

Scoring reality
Translation contributes 25 points. A balanced learner beats someone who only memorises verb lists.

READER PP. 5-12

2. Non-finite foundations

Finite verbs carry tense and agreement. Non-finite forms do not. The three non-finite form families are the infinitive, the -ing form and the past participle. In a finite verb phrase, the first verb is finite; later verbs are non-finite.

Form	Function	Example
to-infinitive	complement after many verbs/adjectives/nouns	hope to pass
bare infinitive	after make/let/have, would rather, had better	made me revise
gerund	noun-like -ing form	Revising helps.
present participle	progressive/adjectival/verbal -ing form	was revising; students waiting
past participle	perfect/passive/adjectival form	has finished; was checked

HIGH-FREQUENCY GOVERNORS

Gerund	To-infinitive	Bare infinitive
admit, avoid, deny, enjoy	decide, expect, hope, manage	make/let/have + object
imagine, mind, risk, suggest	offer, promise, refuse, seem	would rather / had better
cannot help, feel like	tend, want, wish	why not / rather than
look forward to, worth	adjective + to-infinitive	help + (to) infinitive

Preposition rule
A preposition takes an -ing form: by working, without checking, instead of guessing, look forward to hearing. Here to is a preposition.

READER PP. 9-12

3. Non-finites: meaning-changing pairs

Pair	First meaning	Second meaning
stop doing / stop to do	end the activity	pause another action in order to act
remember doing / remember to do	memory of a past event	remember a future obligation
forget doing / forget to do	forget a past event	fail to perform an intended action
regret doing / regret to do	sorrow about the past	formal announcement of bad news
try doing / try to do	test a method	make an effort, perhaps fail
mean doing / mean to do	involve	intend
go on doing / go on to do	continue the same action	move to the next action
used to do / be used to doing	discontinued past habit	be accustomed to

SPECIAL STRUCTURES

- Authority verbs: allow smoking, but allow visitors to smoke.
- Passive meaning: The roof needs repairing = needs to be repaired.
- Perception: I heard them sing (whole action) vs singing (in progress).
- Progressive governor: The sea level is starting to rise, not starting rising.
- Object before form: I dislike people telling me what to think.

Common exam trap
Do not decide from the German infinitive. Decide from the English governor and the intended meaning.

READER PP. 13-14

4. Present forms

Simple present use	Typical context	Example
habitual	regular habit + frequency	I revise every evening.
unrestrictive	truth, fact, proverb	Water freezes at 0 C.
instantaneous	commentary, ceremony, performative	I apologise.
imaginary	instructions, itinerary, joke	You press this button.
historic present	vivid past / communication verb	I hear you changed course.
timetable future	fixed external schedule	The exam starts at 14:00.
future sub-clause	after when/as soon as/if	I will call when I arrive.
state verb	know, believe, belong, have	I know the answer.

Present progressive use	Meaning	Example
ongoing/incomplete	action viewed in progress	I am writing a guide.
temporary	limited duration or habit	I am walking until the car is fixed.
always + progressive	speaker annoyance	You are always interrupting.
arranged future	intention with present arrangement	We are meeting at six.

State-verb nuance
Be can become progressive for temporary behaviour: You are being strangely silly today.

READER PP. 15-16

5. Perfect and past forms

Form	Use	Example
present perfect	unspecified past	Have you ever tried it?
present perfect	continuing period	I have lived here for two years.
present perfect	current result	I have broken my glasses.
present perfect progressive	duration/activity	I have been studying for three hours.
present perfect progressive	present secondary result	I have been cutting onions.
simple past	definite finished past	I saw her yesterday.
simple past	narrative/habitual past	He opened the door and entered.
modal past	hypothetical present	If only I knew.
past progressive	background/interruption	I was cooking when she called.
past perfect	anterior to past point	They had left before we arrived.

Seit in translation
A situation continuing now normally uses present perfect or present perfect progressive: I have lived here since 2024; I have been studying for three hours.

Finished-time rule
Yesterday, last week, in 2022 and two days ago normally require simple past, not present perfect.

READER P. 17

6. Ways of expressing future time

Construction	Controlled event	External event
will	spontaneous decision	factual prediction
going to	present intention	prediction from evidence
present progressive	arranged intention	not normally used
simple present	not normally used	timetable/fixed fact
future progressive	action in progress	matter-of-course future

PERFECT FUTURES

- Future perfect: completed before a future point - By Friday I will have finished.
- Future perfect progressive: duration viewed retrospectively from a future point - By July she will have been studying for two years.

FAST CONTRASTS

Prompt	Best form	Reason
The phone is ringing.	I will answer it.	decision made now
Look at those clouds.	It is going to rain.	present evidence
The room is booked.	We are meeting at six.	arrangement
Official schedule	The train leaves at eight.	timetable
At this time tomorrow	We will be writing.	future in progress

READER PP. 18-19

7. Conditionals and reported speech

Conditional	If-clause	Main clause	Meaning
I	present	will + infinitive	probable/open
II	past	would + infinitive	improbable/hypothetical
III	past perfect	would have + participle	impossible past

- If + should: unlikely future - If she should call, tell her to wait.
- If + were to: remote supposition - If I were to see him, I would speak to him.
- If + will/would: possible when it means willingness/politeness, not ordinary futurity.

BACKSHIFT

Direct form	After past reporting verb
present	past
present progressive	past progressive
present perfect / simple past	past perfect
will	would
can	could
may	might

- No backshift is required after a present reporting verb.
- A timeless truth or still-valid fact may remain present.
- Reported imperative: tell/order/ask + object + to-infinitive.
- Could, would, should, might, ought to, used to and had better normally remain unchanged.

READER PP. 20-21

8. Modality: judge the meaning first

Extrinsic modality expresses the speaker's judgement about the likelihood or certainty of the proposition. Intrinsic modality concerns an agent's freedom or control: obligation, permission, prohibition, willingness and related meanings.

Extrinsic meaning	Modal	Example
logical necessity	must	She must have studied.
negative logical necessity	cannot / could not	He cannot have left.
expectation	should / ought to	You should pass.
prediction	will	It will improve.
factual possibility	may	It may happen.
theoretical possibility	can	Mistakes can occur.
possibility	could	It could happen.
less likely possibility	might	It might happen.

Cannot vs may not
Cannot be true = impossible. May not be true = it is possible that it is not true.

READER PP. 22-23

9. Intrinsic modals and modal idioms

Meaning	Form	Key distinction
strong obligation	must	speaker authority
strong obligation	have to	external authority/circumstances
weak obligation/advice	should / ought to	recommendation
strong advice	had better	urgent; negative consequence implied
no obligation	need not	speaker authority
no obligation	do not need/have to	external circumstances
permission	may/can/could/might	increasingly formal/polite by context
prohibition	must not	strong command not to act
no permission	may not / cannot	weaker prohibition possible
willingness/request	will / would	agent willingness
offer/formal intention	shall	Shall we...? / We shall...

Must not vs do not have to
Must not means forbidden. Do not have to means there is no obligation. This contrast is a favourite translation trap.

READER PP. 23-25

10. Assorted modal meanings

Form	Meaning	Example / note
can	general ability	I can swim.
could	general past ability	I could climb every tree.
was/were able to	specific fulfilled past ability	They were able to escape.
be to	order	You are to report now.
be to	formal plan	The president is to speak.
be to	fate viewed later	They were to meet again.
be supposed to	rumour	They are supposed to be rich.
be supposed to	expected duty	Are we supposed to submit this?
will / would	characteristic behaviour	Every evening he would wait.
used to	discontinued habit/state	She used to live here.
dare	boldness/challenge	Dare you climb it?

German sollen
Choose by meaning: should/ought to, had better, be to, be supposed to/be said to, or sometimes shall. Do not translate mechanically.

READER PP. 24-25

11. Modal perfects and question tags

Construction	What it implies
must have done	strong deduction about a past event
cannot have done	past event is logically impossible
could/might have done	past possibility existed but was not realised in the contrast
need not have done	the action happened but was unnecessary
should have done	expected/right action was not performed

QUESTION TAGS AFTER IMPERATIVES

- Positive imperative: Sit down, will you / won't you?
- Negative imperative: Don't tell anyone, will you?

FORM ORDER

A modal is finite and takes a bare infinitive. Perfect modal structure: modal + have + past participle. Passive perfect modal structure: modal + have + been + past participle.

Meaning can flip
I need not go tomorrow means the action is unnecessary and probably will not happen. I need not have gone means it did happen.

READER PP. 27-29

12. Relative-clause fundamentals

Feature	Defining	Non-defining
function	identifies/restricts antecedent	adds removable information
commas	no	yes
that	possible	not possible
zero pronoun	object gap only	not possible
who/which	possible	possible
fronted preposition	whom/which	whom/which

CASE INSIDE THE RELATIVE CLAUSE

Case	Personal	Non-personal	Example
subject	who / that	which / that	the person who called
object	who/whom/that/zero	which/that/zero	the book C I bought
prepositional	with whom / who C ... with	with which / which C ... with	the person with whom I spoke
genitive	whose	whose / of which	a castle whose roof...

Contact clause
Omit the relative pronoun only in a defining clause when the pronoun is not the subject.

READER PP. 28-31

13. Relative-clause special cases

Construction	Rule	Example
partitive personal	quantifier + of whom	ten people, few of whom...
partitive thing	quantifier + of which	five books, all of which...
connective which	antecedent can be entire prior clause	He left, which surprised me.
what-clause	what = that which; no separate antecedent	What she said was true.
whoever	the person who / no matter who	Whoever calls, tell them...
whatever	no matter what; unrestricted	Whatever you do...
whichever	selection from a limited set	Choose whichever you prefer.

- Use present forms for future reference after whoever/whatever/whichever.
- That cannot directly follow a preposition.
- A comma can change a clause from identifying to parenthetical information.
- Relative-pronoun case comes from its function inside the relative clause, not from the antecedent's role in the main clause.

READER PP. 32-36

14. Adverbs and normal word order

An adverb is a word class. An adverbial is a function and can be realised by a word, phrase or clause.

Quiz correction: the reader lists 13 types of adverbs: place, definite time, indefinite time, definite frequency, indefinite frequency, manner, degree, certainty, completeness, focusing, emphasizing, connecting and comment adverbs. Connecting adverbs count separately.

Position	Typical material	Rule / example
front	connecting, comment, viewpoint, time	Unfortunately, the train was late.
mid	degree, indefinite time/frequency, focusing	She often goes. She is often late.
end	place, definite time/frequency, manner	Read the text carefully tomorrow.

MID POSITION

- Usually before the lexical verb: She often goes.
- After be: She is often late.
- After the first auxiliary: She will probably have arrived.
- Degree/manner after all auxiliaries: It has been completely revised.
- With contracted negative, adverb before auxiliary: She probably will not come.

MULTIPLE END ADVERBIALS

- Default: manner - place - time.
- After motion: place - manner - time.
- Move one item earlier if three end adverbials make the sentence heavy.

READER PP. 36-37

15. Inversion

Fronted negative or restrictive adverbials trigger auxiliary-subject order. Common triggers include never, rarely, only, little, hardly, no sooner, at no time, under no circumstances and on no account.

Base sentence	Fronted form	Mechanism
I have never seen it.	Never have I seen it.	move existing auxiliary
She rarely visited.	Rarely did she visit.	add did + base form
My surprise was so great...	So great was my surprise...	invert be and subject
The bus comes here.	Here comes the bus.	directional + noun subject
We go off.	Off we go.	no inversion with pronoun subject

No inversion
No doubt, in no time, nevertheless, nonetheless, not long after and with no difficulty do not trigger inversion.

Base-form check
After do/does/did, use the base form: Only yesterday did I meet, not did I met.

READER PP. 38-39

16. The definite article and zero article

Use the	Use zero article
unique entities: the earth, the sky	general abstract nouns: life, beauty
noun identified by phrase/clause	general uncountable nouns: sugar, advice
superlatives, ordinals, only	general plural class: Dogs are loyal.
adjective as class: the rich	most names, countries, towns, streets, lakes
rivers, seas, mountain chains, deserts	body/clothing normally with possessive
instruments and dances	institutional school/court/prison/hospital
specified uncountable/plural noun	most illnesses

MEANING CONTRASTS

Zero / possessive	Definite article
go to court = use the institution	go to the court = visit a specific place
raise his hand = owner relation	hit him in the hand = affected body part
Sugar dissolves. = substance generally	The sugar in this cup... = specified
Dogs bark. = class generally	The dogs next door... = identified group

READER PP. 39-40

17. The indefinite article and quantity words

Use a/an	Use zero
singular countable non-specific noun	plural noun
one representative of a class	abstract or uncountable noun
profession	material
a couple/dozen/hundred/million	meal name without modifier
rate: 60 miles an hour	unique title after appoint/elect
singular countable exclamation	own without possessive is impossible

Form	Countability	Meaning
few	plural count	hardly any; negative
a few	plural count	some; positive
little	uncountable	hardly any; negative
a little	uncountable	some; positive

- Profession: She is a teacher.
- Unique title: They appointed her Head Librarian.
- Meal: We had breakfast, but we had a good breakfast.
- Own: She has her own office.

25 POINTS

18. Translation method

1. Mark the time line. Finished past, continuing up to now, earlier past, future viewpoint or hypothetical distance?
2. Identify modal meaning. Deduction, authority, external obligation, advice, no obligation, prohibition, ability, rumour or fate?
3. Choose the non-finite pattern. Which English word or preposition governs the next form?
4. Build clauses. Conditional sequence, reported-speech backshift, relative type/case and comma placement.
5. Check inversion. Never, nowhere, only then and similar fronted items change the order.
6. Check determiners. Countability, general vs identified reference, institution vs place and possessive body parts.
7. Polish wording. Keep the grammatical target, but make the final sentence natural English.

German cue	English target	Model fragment
seit drei Jahren	present perfect (progressive) + for	have been studying for three years
noch nie at the start	negative inversion	Never has she...
solltest lieber	had better + bare infinitive	had better leave
von denen wenige	partitive relative	few of whom
wenn ich gewusst hatte	third conditional	if I had known...
was ich schade fand	connective which	which I thought was a pity
es muss passiert sein	must + perfect infinitive	must have happened

Auto-grading warning
Moodle can reject a valid alternative that is not stored. For learning, compare grammatical targets as well as exact wording.

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

19. Mini translation set

1. Ich lerne seit drei Stunden für die Klausur.

2. Nie zuvor hatte er eine so schwierige Aufgabe gesehen.

3. Du solltest lieber sofort gehen.

4. Es gab zehn Bücher, von denen keines hilfreich war.

5. Wenn ich es gewusst hätte, hätte ich dich angerufen.

6. Ich erinnere mich daran, ihn dort getroffen zu haben.

7. Ich rufe dich an, sobald ich ankomme.

8. Es muss geregnet haben; die Straße ist nass.

9. Sie konnte die Tür schließlich öffnen.

10. Er ging vor Gericht, besuchte später aber das Gerichtsgebäude.

REVIEW

20. Models and final checklist

- 1. I have been studying for the exam for three hours.
- 2. Never before had he seen such a difficult task.
- 3. You had better leave immediately.
- 4. There were ten books, none of which was helpful.
- 5. If I had known, I would have called you.
- 6. I remember meeting him there.
- 7. I will call you as soon as I arrive.
- 8. It must have rained; the road is wet.
- 9. She was finally able to open the door.
- 10. He went to court, but later visited the court building.

FINAL CHECK

1. I can explain each meaning-changing non-finite pair.
2. I choose tense and aspect from the full time line, not one keyword alone.
3. I distinguish must/have to, must not/do not have to and could/was able to.
4. I can build defining, non-defining, contact, partitive and connective relative clauses.
5. I use do-support correctly after negative/restrictive fronting.
6. I can explain article choice by meaning, not only memorised phrases.
7. I have completed at least one timed mock and repaired every saved mistake.

Last instruction
On exam day, read the complete context before filling any gap. Many wrong options are grammatical in isolation but wrong for the intended meaning.